The UK Tax Exit Checklist

Everything you need to sort with HMRC before and after the move

By Patrick — DubaiExpat
dubaiexpat.co.uk

UK Tax Exit Checklist Everything to sort with HMRC before and after your move to Dubai dubaiexpat.co.uk Moving to Dubai means leaving the UK tax system — but HMRC doesn't let go easily. This checklist covers every step you need to take, from P85 filing to National Insurance decisions, so nothing falls through the cracks. Tick each box as you complete it. Items are in recommended chronological order. Before You Leave the UK Action Detail When n Confirm your UK departure date The date you leave determines your tax 3-6 months residency split year. Keep evidence: before flight booking, tenancy end date, employer letter. n Run the Statutory Residence Test (SRT) Work through HMRC's RDR3 guidance 3 months before to confirm you'll be non-resident. Key: spend fewer than 16 days in the UK in the tax year of departure (or fewer than 46 if no UK ties). n Notify your employer Your employer needs to apply the Before last UK split-year treatment and stop deducting payday PAYE from your departure date. Request a P45 for the final UK pay period. n File form P85 with HMRC P85 ('Leaving the UK') notifies HMRC of On or after your departure. Can be filed online. departure Triggers any tax refund for the partial year. Do NOT wait until the next tax year. n Decide on National Insurance You can pay voluntary Class 2 NI Before or after contributions to protect your UK State Pension. Current rate: approx. £3.45/week. You have 6 years to backfill gaps. n Check your UK State Pension forecast Log into gov.uk/check-state-pension to Before departure see your current NI record and how many more years you need for full pension (35 years). n Sort private pension access If you have a UK workplace pension, Before departure update your address. Check if your provider allows international withdrawals. Do NOT transfer to a QROPS without advice. n Cancel or redirect UK mail HMRC correspondence will still go to Before departure your last UK address. Set up Royal Mail redirection (12 months) or update your HMRC address to a UK-based trusted contact. After Arrival in Dubai Action Detail When n Confirm split-year treatment applies If you left mid-tax year, check which First month split-year case applies to you (Cases 1-8 in HMRC guidance). This determines which income is taxable in the UK. n File your UK Self Assessment (if required) If you were self-employed, had rental By 31 January income, or earned over £150k, you'll need to file a Self Assessment for the departure year. Deadline: 31 Jan following the tax year. n Register for Self Assessment abroad Form SA109 declares your non-resident With SA return (SA109) status. Attach it to your Self Assessment return. Claim split-year treatment here. n Set up voluntary NI contributions Contact HMRC's NI office (not the Within 6 months general helpline) for CF83 form. Set up annual payment via bank transfer. Keep receipts. n Notify UK bank accounts Update your address with UK banks. First month Some accounts can't be held by non-residents — check before your old UK address goes stale. n Check Double Taxation Agreement (DTA) The UK-UAE DTA means you won't be Ongoing taxed twice on most income. But UK rental income, pensions, and capital gains have specific rules. n Handle UK property (if applicable) UK rental income is still taxable in the If applicable UK. Register with HMRC's Non-Resident Landlord Scheme (NRLS) to avoid 20% withholding by your letting agent. n Keep travel records Track every day you spend in the UK. If Ongoing you breach the SRT day count, you could be reclassified as UK tax resident. Use an app or spreadsheet. Key HMRC Deadlines Deadline Details P85 submission As soon as you leave (no fixed deadline, but sooner = faster refund) Self Assessment registration By 5 October following the tax year you left Self Assessment filing (online) By 31 January following the tax year Self Assessment tax payment By 31 January (same deadline) NI voluntary contributions Can backfill up to 6 years — but don't leave it late Non-Resident Landlord Scheme Before first UK rental income or 20% is withheld Common Mistakes to Avoid Not filing P85: HMRC won't know you've left. You'll keep getting tax bills based on full-year UK residence. Spending too many days in the UK: The SRT is strict. Even short visits count. Track every trip. Ignoring National Insurance: Each missing year costs you roughly £275/year in State Pension. Voluntary contributions are cheap — pay them. Transferring pension to a QROPS without advice: QROPS transfers can trigger a 25% tax charge. Get

independent financial advice before moving any pension. Forgetting UK rental income: Just because you live in Dubai doesn't mean UK property income is tax-free. Register with NRLS immediately. Not keeping records: HMRC can query your non-resident status years later. Keep flight records, utility bills, and employment contracts as proof of Dubai residence. Created by dubaiexpat.co.uk — The expat's guide to moving from the UK to Dubai. This checklist is for general guidance only and is not tax advice. Tax rules change — always verify deadlines and thresholds with HMRC or a qualified tax adviser. Last updated April 2026.